

Wahkiakum Common Ground

Principles to Achieve Multi-Benefit Watershed Restoration

VISION: A Wahkiakum County that respects the past, thrives in the present, and adapts to future challenges by using a collaborative community-focused approach that fosters a healthy environment, rural lifestyle, and vibrant economy.

COMMON GROUND PRIORITIES:

- Reducing the impacts of flooding and erosion on private property and public infrastructure;
- Restoring local watersheds that support abundant salmon and natural resources;
- Boosting the economic vitality of the county; and
- Improving community resilience to natural hazards and long-term social, environmental, and economic changes.

PROJECT PARTICIPANTS: Forty invited leaders included landowners, business owners, the county, municipalities, agencies, tribes, special districts, nonprofit organizations, and technical experts.

PROJECT PRINCIPLES: The group identified common themes or principles that contribute to the Common Ground vision and priorities (above), helping us achieve more together.

**We offer these Principles to guide watershed restoration
and associated activities across Wahkiakum County.**

We can benefit people and ecosystems by:

- ☐ Reducing erosion of private property, including agricultural lands and forestland, and its negative impacts on public infrastructure
- ☐ Pursuing projects that reduce flood impacts, protect infrastructure, and improve safety
- ☐ Working with landowners and neighbors to identify their needs, and designing projects to support the land, lifestyle, and wildlife we all love
- ☐ Finding ways to increase mutual benefit and to compensate landowners for their contributions
- ☐ Ensuring that watershed restoration efforts actively engage diverse partners in planning and implementation

We can protect and enhance water quality, watershed processes, and habitats for fish by:

- ☐ Reintroducing natural elements (large woody debris, deep pools, side channels, and forested shorelines) to mimic the old-growth ecosystem in which local salmon evolved
- ☐ Adding in-stream features to create habitat complexity, which increases sediment capture and slows stream flow, reducing bank erosion and flooding
- ☐ Planting and retaining native trees and shrubs in the floodplain to increase bank stability, provide shade to help keep water cool, and provide insects and leaves as food for fish and other aquatic life
- ☐ Restoring fish passage by removing or redesigning barriers to upstream spawning grounds and downstream nursery habitats critical to the salmon life cycle
- ☐ Reconnecting streams to their floodplains—providing space for flood waters to disperse and slow, allowing sediments to enrich floodplain soils, and creating habitat for young fish and other wildlife
- ☐ Embracing working lands while achieving ecological goals

We can stimulate the local economy by:

- ☐ Prioritizing local contractors, workers, materials, and equipment
- ☐ Balancing needs of existing timber, agriculture, and fishing industries with the health of the watershed
- ☐ Promoting workforce development through job training and educational programs that enhance the ability of future generations to shape and benefit from this work
- ☐ Contributing to an increase in salmon populations that benefit local businesses dependent upon commercial and recreational fisheries
- ☐ Considering how restoration design may impact property values
- ☐ Supporting Chinook Indian Nation in obtaining restoration of federal recognition that would bring funding into the community
- ☐ Increasing opportunities to access and appreciate the rivers and forests to boost tourism
- ☐ Coordinating across businesses to create community-driven activities to attract visitors year-round

We can carry out this work collaboratively and efficiently by:

- ☐ Collaborating with diverse cross-sector partners who bring expertise in grant-writing, project management, hydrology, engineering, community engagement, permitting, and local knowledge
- ☐ Seeking multiple sources of funding, and using creative cost-sharing to support projects
- ☐ Focusing on long-term and sustainable solutions that improve social, environmental, and economic factors across time and multiple projects
- ☐ Recognizing the need for adaptive management to address needs that might change over time
- ☐ Appreciating the time required for collaboration, planning, permitting, and construction
- ☐ Funding long-term stewardship and maintenance of restoration projects
- ☐ Seeking compromise and common ground, recognizing that this work involves working with partners who have different goals and needs, and with county residents whose buy-in is crucial to project success
- ☐ Recognizing the immense value and importance of engaging the Chinook Indian Nation and creating capacity for tribal participation and leadership in restoration efforts.

We can inform, educate, and engage residents in watershed restoration by:

- ☐ Learning from previous projects and using existing examples of success to educate the public, promote acceptance of projects, and leverage neighbor-to-neighbor networking
- ☐ Increasing community awareness of the connection of watershed restoration and salmon recovery to a prosperous local economy and quality of life, through news stories and other learning opportunities
- ☐ Improving community understanding of the limitations, regulations, and complexities guiding restoration projects
- ☐ Providing workshops, field trips, and opportunities for discussion to foster trust, shared learning, and local buy-in to support long-term project success
- ☐ Engaging the community in project development, valuing their local knowledge, values, and expertise

Wahkiakum County Marine Resources Committee ♦ WSU Wahkiakum County Extension

Partners: Lower Columbia Fish Recovery Board ♦ Pacific Conservation District

Cascadia Coastlines and Peoples Hazards Research Hub ♦ Washington Sea Grant

Funded by: Coastal Hazards Organizational Resilience Team, <https://wacoastalnetwork.com/cohort/>

SUMMARY: We learned that watershed restoration is complex and has multiple benefits:

- Restoration of local watersheds and salmon populations improves quality of life, benefitting people, ecosystems, and the economy of Wahkiakum County
- Increased information exchange across residents, landowners, agencies, tribes, organizations, and local governments decreases tensions, builds relationships, and grows trust
- Public and private concerns can work together on restoration projects for a common purpose and mutual benefits
- Watershed restoration projects are voluntary and can be designed to address landowner needs
- Collaboration among agencies, tribes, organizations, local governments, residents, and landowners to address immediate needs and to implement long-term strategies is necessary to achieve watershed restoration
- Shoreline planning and regulations can be designed to protect the benefits that natural shorelines provide in reducing flooding and erosion, and providing habitat for fish—while also meeting the needs of people
- Achieving landscape-scale habitat restoration requires persistence and patience, and long-term engagement
- Recovery of fish to healthy, harvestable levels takes a long time, and success must be assessed in the long-term
- There is no one-size-fits-all solution to watershed restoration; strategies must be sensitive to the environmental context, landowner needs, community concerns, agency regulations, tribal heritage, and available resources

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